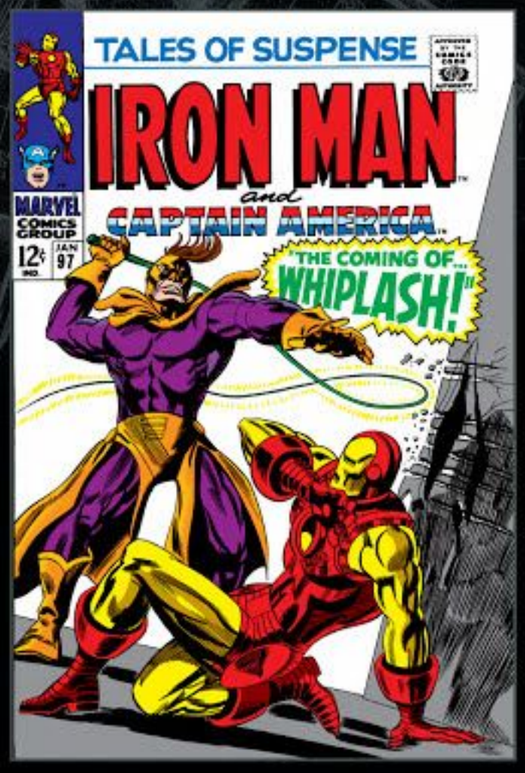
WHIPLASH



The original conception of Whiplash, when he first appeared in a 1967 issue of Tales of Suspense by Stan Lee and Gene Colan, was quite different from what appears in Iron Man 2. "When he was introduced," says Tom Brevoort, "Whiplash was an assassin working for the Maggia—it's the Mafia, but for super heroes. Tony's cousin had racked up a bunch of gambling debts and they were going to use him to get inside of Stark Industries and make off with stuff. Whiplash was their enforcer. He was a guy in a super hero costume with a big stainless steel whip. He could shatter steel with it, but he wasn't really a super-high-tech villain."

About five years earlier, another character was introduced—the Soviet counterpart of Iron Man, the Crimson Dynamo. "Crimson Dynamo was the first of the mirror-image Iron Man characters," says Brevoort, referring to the tendency of Iron Man to come up against other armored foes. As that first story begins. "[Soviet Premier] Khrushchev is meeting with Anton Vanko, who's put the suit together, and he's going to go to the West and topple Iron Man."

"Back when the books were written," says Jon Favreau, "the Soviet Union was the big threat, and that dissipated. But now, whom we have friction with on the world stage seems to be coming back around to the old favorites from the comics. We wanted to reinvent the guy, but there was something interesting and cool and retro about having a Russian. And Mickey Rourke had spent some time there and was intrigued by the idea. You get the sense that the criminals that come out of Russia are a little more hard-boiled than the softer criminals from the Unites States. So, it added a layer of ferocity to the guy."



"So we kind of started taking the backstory from Crimson Dynamo," says Jeremy Latcham, "and the idea of this Whiplash character, and kind of melding them together in a way that hopefully feels like we're telling a cool, new story that you haven't seen before."



In Iron Man #146, Whiplash was rechristened as Blacklash—now in the employ of the evil financier Justin Hammer. "Blacklash was like Whiplash, but with a black costume," elaborates Brevoort. "Much like Iron Man would get a new coat of paint, new suit, the notion was let's make this guy seem like a credible threat, let's make him more dangerous, let's give him some more capabilities."

Iron Man 2's Ivan Vanko likewise goes through his own transformation, courtesy of Justin Hammer—but this time, the power-up is much more than cosmetic. And more importantly, this time, with this Whiplash, the vendetta against Tony Stark is personal.



Gene Colan (top left), Ivan Gomez Montero (bottom left), Brandon Peterson (top right), Bob Layton (bottom right).